Letter from Birmingham Jail

Rev. Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. · April 16, 1963 · excerpts

Source: The King Center, thekingcenter.org; reprinted in Why We Can't Wait (1964).

King wrote this open letter from jail after his arrest during the Birmingham Campaign of 1963. The immediate provocation was a public statement by eight white Alabama clergymen calling his nonviolent direct action 'unwise and untimely.' King's response — drafted on the margins of a newspaper and on jail toilet paper — laid out his moral philosophy: the distinction between just and unjust laws, the obligation to direct action when negotiation fails, and a famous critique of the 'white moderate.'

Connect: King's argument for direct action came under fire from 'moderate' clergy. Compare his response to the pressure Frederick Douglass faced (Class 14) from white abolitionists who wanted him to speak more 'politely.'

Key Passages

Why direct action

> You may well ask: 'Why direct action? Why sit-ins, marches and so forth? Isn't negotiation a better path?' You are quite right in calling for negotiation. … The purpose of our direct-action program is to create a situation so crisis-packed that it will inevitably open the door to negotiation.

Just vs. unjust laws

> How does one determine whether a law is just or unjust? A just law is a man-made code that squares with the moral law or the law of God. An unjust law is a code that is out of harmony with the moral law. … Any law that uplifts human personality is just. Any law that degrades human personality is unjust.

On the 'white moderate'

> I have almost reached the regrettable conclusion that the Negro's great stumbling block in his stride toward freedom is not the White Citizen's Counciler or the Ku Klux Klanner, but the white moderate, who is more devoted to 'order' than to justice; who prefers a negative peace which is the absence of tension to a positive peace which is the presence of justice.

On waiting

> For years now I have heard the word 'Wait!' … This 'Wait' has almost always meant 'Never.' We must come to see, with one of our distinguished jurists, that 'justice too long delayed is justice denied.'

HAPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Context *What was happening when this was written?*	The Birmingham Campaign (1963): nonviolent protests against segregation in one of the most segregated cities in the South, and King's arrest.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	The eight white Alabama clergymen who criticized the protests, and more broadly white moderate Americans and the national public.

HAPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Martin Luther King Jr., a Baptist minister and civil rights leader writing from jail, committed to nonviolence and Christian moral principles.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Evidence Beyond Docs — CRM (1 pt): Identify TWO outside pieces of evidence (events, organizations, leaders) you could use in a CRM essay.

2. Why did King write to the WHITE clergymen rather than to Black readers or to the federal government?

3. Identify ONE specific result of the Birmingham Campaign in 1963.